

Committee: Organisation of American States

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Agenda 1: Threats to the Political Stronghold of the Venezuelan President and his Coerced Abduction

Introduction to Agenda

Venezuela has been one of the most politically unstable regions in the Western world. Decades of economic collapse and democratic undermining have led the country to split into two opposing camps, with the government that came into power illegally and the opposition that has consistently challenged its authority. This agenda item focuses on the recent developments that led to the kidnapping of the Venezuelan president and the instability of the government that has the potential to cause regional instability.

First of all, the situation in Venezuela raises numerous questions that need to be addressed. The most pressing matter concerns the illegality of the abduction. There is no doubt that the actions of the Venezuelan president have been criminal; however, removing him from power may have far-reaching consequences, such as establishing a dangerous precedent. Furthermore, the illegitimacy of the new government led by Rodríguez is controversial and may result in the recognition dilemma. In other words, members of the Organization must decide whether to recognize Rodríguez's government as legitimate in order to avoid further instability in the region.

Indeed, the Organization must address this crisis in order to prevent it from becoming a persistent source of tension. One of the arguments presented is related to the "narco-state," which seems to justify the actions of the new government. However, it contradicts the principles of sovereignty and non-intervention that have guided the Organization's foreign policy for decades. It is necessary to find a compromise that would allow the Organization to condemn the Venezuelan government's policies without violating the norm of non-intervention.

In addition, it is vital that the Organization establishes a timeframe for resolving the crisis in Venezuela. Although the Organization does not have a direct mandate to

intervene in Venezuela, it should encourage a free and fair election as soon as possible. Such measures would alleviate the instability of the situation and prevent regional threats, including mass immigration and economic spillovers. The foreign policy implications of the crisis are also complex, considering the potential involvement of regional actors such as the US, Colombia, Russia, and Cuba. It is crucial that the Organization remembers the importance of collective security and does not allow the crisis to derail its foreign policy.

Overall, the agenda item is of great importance because it determines the Organization's ability to act in situations when a country illegally seizes power. The decisions that the Organization makes in relation to the crisis in Venezuela will set the precedent for future interventions. In other words, the agenda item determines the Organization's potential to promote democracy, stability, and unity in the region.

Key terms and definitions

Key Terms and Definitions

Coerced Abduction: The forced removal of a head of state through pressure, threat, or physical force outside constitutional or legal channels, distinct from a lawful arrest carried out under due process.

De Facto Authority: Control over a state's government and institutions in practice, regardless of whether that control has been formally or legally sanctioned, a status the Rodríguez government currently occupies pending international recognition.

De Jure Authority: The legally recognized right to govern, typically granted through constitutional process, election, or formal international acknowledgment, separate from whoever actually holds power on the ground.

Collective Non-Recognition Doctrine: A precedent in international relations where states jointly withhold recognition from a government that assumed power through unconstitutional means, intended to discourage future extra-constitutional seizures across the hemisphere.

Selective Enforcement: The inconsistent application of international norms or labels, such as the "narco-state" designation, depending on a state's strategic

alignment rather than a uniform legal standard, raising concerns of political bias in how crises are judged.

Conditional Recognition: A diplomatic strategy in which a state or organization agrees to recognize a government only once it meets specific benchmarks, such as committing to elections or accepting international oversight, used as leverage to shape political outcomes.

Constitutional Continuity: The principle that governance must proceed through an unbroken, legally established line of succession, a concept thrown into crisis when the figure responsible for maintaining that continuity is the one forcibly removed.

Humanitarian Pretext: The use of humanitarian justifications, such as protecting civilians or restoring stability, to legitimize what may substantively be a politically motivated intervention in a sovereign state's internal affairs.

Sphere of Influence: A region in which a foreign power exerts significant political, economic, or military control over the decisions of another state, relevant to understanding how the US, Russia, or Cuba's involvement may shape Venezuela's trajectory.

Democratic Erosion: The gradual weakening of democratic institutions and norms, including electoral integrity and checks on executive power, which forms the backdrop against which this crisis must be evaluated.

Precedent Setting: The establishment of a decision or response that becomes a reference point for how similar future crises are handled, meaning the Committee's ruling here could shape how the OAS reacts to any future coerced removal of a head of state in the region.

Interim Government: A temporary administrative body installed to manage state affairs during a transitional period, often lacking full legitimacy until validated through elections or broader political consensus.

Regime Legitimacy: The degree to which a government's authority is accepted as rightful by its population and the international community, shaped by factors such as electoral processes, adherence to law, and respect for civil liberties.

Diplomatic Isolation: The deliberate withdrawal of formal diplomatic ties, recognition, or engagement by other states as a means of pressuring a government, often used as a tool short of direct intervention.

Regional Stability Doctrine: The broader principle guiding OAS decision-making that prioritizes maintaining peace, order, and predictable governance across member states, sometimes placed in tension with strict adherence to sovereignty or non-intervention.

History and Background

Venezuela's descent into political and economic turmoil traces back to the death of President Hugo Chávez in 2013 and the subsequent rise of Nicolás Maduro, whose leadership has since been marked by authoritarian consolidation and a collapsing economy. The country's GDP fell by roughly 80 percent in less than a decade, driven by corruption, food shortages, unemployment, and severe mismanagement of the oil sector that forms the backbone of Venezuela's economy. By 2023, consumer prices were still tripling annually even after the worst of the hyperinflationary period had passed, keeping Venezuela among the highest inflation rates in the world. This economic freefall eroded the government's domestic legitimacy and fueled the political fractures that continue to define the crisis today.

The humanitarian toll of this collapse has been staggering and remains one of the defining features of the modern Venezuelan crisis. By the end of 2024, more than 7.9 million Venezuelans had left the country, draining much of its skilled workforce and underscoring the scale of the catastrophe. Nearly 82 percent of the remaining population lives in poverty, with 53 percent in extreme poverty, unable to reliably access basic food. This mass exodus has placed significant strain on neighboring states, with Colombia alone hosting approximately 2.8 million Venezuelan migrants, while Brazil, Chile, Ecuador, and Peru have also become key host countries.

Politically, the legitimacy of Maduro's government has been a recurring point of hemispheric division since his disputed re-election in 2018. The opposition-led National Assembly declared Juan Guaidó interim president in 2019, prompting a wave of competing recognition across the Americas that fractured the OAS's ability to respond with a unified voice. However, international support for Guaidó gradually weakened over subsequent years, with the United States eventually following the Venezuelan opposition's own lead in revoking his recognition as the country's

legitimate leader, while Maduro's international standing partially recovered as leaders more sympathetic to him took office in Mexico, Colombia, and Brazil.

Economic conditions briefly stabilized in the early 2020s after the government pursued partial liberalization measures, easing price controls and permitting foreign-currency transactions. Hyperinflation officially ended by December 2020, and the economy grew moderately in the years that followed. This recovery, however, proved fragile. Renewed political consolidation following the 2025 regional and local elections deepened uncertainty, and in May 2025 the reimposition of sectoral U.S. sanctions on Venezuelan oil exports forced the country to sell crude at steep discounts on informal markets, reversing much of the earlier progress. Annual inflation, which had fallen to 71.7 percent in 2024 from 190 percent the year before, began climbing again as the sanctions took hold.

It is against this backdrop of chronic instability, economic fragility, and unresolved questions of political legitimacy that the current crisis must be understood. The coerced abduction of the sitting president did not emerge in a vacuum; it is the latest and most acute manifestation of years of contested authority, foreign interference, and a population pushed to the brink by sustained hardship. Understanding this history is essential for the Committee to evaluate not only the immediate legality of the seizure, but the deeper structural forces that made such a rupture possible in the first place.

Present Situation

Venezuela currently stands at one of the most precarious junctures in its modern political history. The coerced abduction of the sitting president has thrown the country into a state of constitutional limbo, with no clear or universally accepted framework for determining who holds legitimate authority in the interim. The emergence of the Rodríguez government has only intensified this ambiguity, as member states across the hemisphere remain divided over whether to extend recognition, withhold it pending clarification, or condition it on specific commitments such as a defined electoral timeline.

This political rupture has occurred against a backdrop of severe economic fragility. The renewed sanctions imposed on Venezuelan oil exports have forced the country to sell crude at steep discounts on informal markets, reversing much of the modest recovery achieved in previous years and reigniting inflationary pressures. With poverty already affecting a large majority of the population and millions having fled

the country in search of stability elsewhere, the domestic conditions inside Venezuela remain volatile, leaving little room for a prolonged period of uncertainty without further deterioration.

Compounding the crisis is the involvement of external actors whose interests do not always align. The United States, having previously withdrawn recognition of past opposition-led claims to power, now faces renewed pressure to take a position on the legitimacy of the current situation. Meanwhile, states such as Russia and Cuba maintain longstanding ties to the Venezuelan government and are likely to resist any framing of the abduction as a justified intervention, while regional actors such as Colombia and Brazil must weigh their own domestic political considerations against the pressure to respond collectively through the OAS.

At the heart of the present debate lies the unresolved tension between the narco-state justification being used to frame the abduction as legitimate and the broader principle of sovereignty that has historically constrained OAS action in the internal affairs of member states. How the Committee chooses to interpret this tension will directly shape whether the organization is seen as upholding a consistent standard of democratic accountability or applying selective judgment based on political convenience.

The situation remains fluid, with no electoral pathway yet established and the legal status of both the abduction and the resulting transitional authority still very much contested. It falls to this Committee to determine whether the current trajectory leads toward a stabilized, internationally endorsed resolution or toward deeper fragmentation, both within Venezuela and across the hemisphere's response to it.

Present Situation

Overview

Venezuela currently stands at one of the most volatile junctures in its modern political history. The coerced abduction of the sitting president has thrown the country into a state of constitutional limbo, echoing but far exceeding the severity of past disputes over the country's democratic order. The Committee inherits not a blank slate, but a decade-long pattern of contested legitimacy that the OAS has repeatedly attempted, and repeatedly failed, to fully resolve.

Historical Precedent Within the OAS

This is not the OAS's first confrontation with a Venezuelan legitimacy crisis. In April 2017, Resolution 1078 declared that the Venezuelan Supreme Court's move to suspend the powers of the National Assembly and arrogate them to itself constituted an alteration of the constitutional order inconsistent with democratic practice. This was followed in June 2018 by Resolution 2929, which declared the illegitimacy of that year's May 20 presidential election, and in January 2019 by a further Permanent Council resolution affirming the right of the peoples of the Americas to democracy under Article 1 of the Inter-American Democratic Charter, alongside a decision to not recognize the legitimacy of Maduro's new presidential term. Most recently, following the disputed July 28, 2024 election, the OAS General Assembly adopted a resolution noting with concern reports of serious irregularities and violence, while reaffirming the Organization's essential purpose of promoting representative democracy with due respect for the principle of non-intervention under Article 2(b) of the OAS Charter.

Legal Mechanisms Currently in Play

The legal architecture available to the Committee remains centered on the Inter-American Democratic Charter's enforcement mechanisms. Article 20 allows any member state to request an immediate convocation of the Permanent Council to assess a situation and undertake the necessary diplomatic initiatives to restore democracy, a provision Secretary General Almagro invoked in 2016 when he concluded that Venezuela's constitutional order had been seriously subverted through repeated unconstitutional actions orchestrated by the Executive Branch. Article 21 goes further, providing the pathway toward suspension of a member state from the Organization if diplomatic efforts fail. Article 11 of the Democratic Charter, invoked in the 2024 resolution, further ties democratic legitimacy to social and economic development, directly linking the current political rupture to Venezuela's ongoing economic collapse. Whether the current abduction and the resulting Rodríguez government trigger these same mechanisms, or represent a scenario the Charter was never designed to address, is now squarely before this Committee.

Divisions Among Member States

Compounding the legal ambiguity is the deep and recurring division in how member states have historically responded to Venezuela's crises. The 2019 recognition of

Juan Guaidó as interim president saw Brazil, Chile, and Colombia align behind an alternative government, while Russia, Cuba, and other allies maintained firm support for Maduro. This split, part of what became known as the Lima Group's coordinated non-recognition stance, ultimately weakened the Guaidó project until even the United States withdrew its recognition by 2023, with Maduro's international standing partially recovering as leaders more sympathetic to him took office in Mexico, Colombia, and Brazil. This precedent looms large over the question of whether recognizing the Rodríguez government would achieve genuine stabilization or simply repeat a cycle of fractured, externally contested legitimacy.

Economic Pressures Shaping the Crisis

Economically, the reimposition of U.S. sectoral sanctions on Venezuelan oil exports in May 2025 has sharpened the stakes considerably, forcing Venezuela to sell crude at steep discounts on informal markets and reversing years of fragile recovery achieved through earlier partial economic liberalization. Inflation, which had fallen to 71.7 percent in 2024 from 190 percent the year prior, began climbing again as the sanctions took hold, reigniting the inflationary pressures that have repeatedly driven Venezuelans into the streets and across borders. With poverty already affecting a large majority of the population, the domestic conditions inside Venezuela remain volatile, leaving little room for a prolonged period of political uncertainty without further deterioration.

Regional and Humanitarian Spillover

The instability is not confined within Venezuela's borders. Mass emigration, already exceeding 7.9 million departures by the end of 2024, continues to place significant strain on host countries across Latin America, with Colombia alone hosting approximately 2.8 million Venezuelan migrants. Any prolonged crisis stemming from the current abduction risks accelerating this outward flow further, deepening the humanitarian and economic burden already shouldered by neighboring OAS member states and complicating the Organization's ability to reach consensus on a unified response.

Outlook for Committee Deliberation

The Committee must therefore weigh not only the immediate legality of the abduction and the recognition status of the Rodríguez government, but also the accumulated weight of a decade of failed diplomatic interventions, competing

resolutions, and an economic crisis that continues to fuel the very instability the OAS has struggled for years to contain. How this body chooses to act, or refrains from acting, will determine whether Venezuela moves toward a credible electoral pathway or descends further into the kind of prolonged, internationally contested paralysis that has already defined much of the past decade.

Causes

1. Authoritarian Consolidation of Power under Maduro

Since assuming the presidency following Hugo Chávez's death in 2013, Maduro has systematically dismantled the institutional checks that once constrained executive authority in Venezuela. A pivotal turning point came in April 2017, when Venezuela's Supreme Court moved to suspend the powers of the opposition-controlled National Assembly and arrogate them to itself, a move the OAS formally condemned through Resolution 1078 as inconsistent with democratic practice and constituting an alteration of the constitutional order. Later that same year, Maduro established a parallel Constituent Assembly, effectively sidelining the legitimate legislature and consolidating legislative authority under loyalist control.

Elections held under his leadership have repeatedly drawn international condemnation for lacking transparency and genuine competition. The May 2018 presidential election, in which Maduro claimed victory, was formally declared illegitimate by the OAS General Assembly through Resolution 2929. The pattern repeated itself following the July 28, 2024 election, when the OAS noted with concern reports of serious irregularities and violence associated with the electoral process, a concern significant enough to prompt a formal General Assembly resolution the following month.

Sub-point: Erosion of Judicial and Legislative Independence

The judiciary, electoral council (CNE), and legislative bodies have become increasingly aligned with the ruling party, functioning less as independent checks and more as instruments reinforcing executive control. Secretary General Almagro's 2016 report to the Permanent Council, invoked under Article 20 of the Inter-American Democratic Charter, concluded that Venezuela's constitutional order had been seriously subverted through repeated unconstitutional actions orchestrated by the Executive Branch, with the Constitutional Chamber of the Supreme Court actively colluding by blocking legislative actions and approved laws.

Sub-point: Reliance on Security Forces and Loyalist Networks

As formal democratic legitimacy has eroded, the government has grown increasingly dependent on security forces, military loyalty, and patronage networks to maintain control, rather than broad-based electoral support. This dependence on coercive rather than institutional authority is precisely the dynamic that has made the country vulnerable to the kind of extra-constitutional rupture now seen in the current abduction crisis.

2. Economic Collapse (Hyperinflation, Sanctions) and Fractured Opposition

Sub-point: The Scale of Economic Collapse

Venezuela's GDP has fallen by roughly 80 percent in less than a decade, one of the steepest peacetime economic contractions recorded anywhere in the world. The crisis, rooted in a sharp decline in global oil prices beginning in 2014 combined with chronic mismanagement of the state oil sector, plunged the country into hyperinflation between 2014 and 2020. Nearly 82 percent of the population now lives in poverty, with 53 percent in extreme poverty, unable to reliably access sufficient food. Income poverty alone nearly tripled from 33.1 percent in 2013 to 96.2 percent by 2019/2020, while extreme poverty rose nearly sevenfold to 79.3 percent over the same period.

Sub-point: The Sanctions Cycle

Economic conditions briefly stabilized after 2020, when the government pursued partial liberalization, easing price controls and permitting foreign-currency transactions; hyperinflation officially ended in December 2020, and the economy grew an estimated 5 percent in 2024. This recovery proved short-lived. In May 2025, the reimposition of U.S. sectoral sanctions on Venezuelan oil exports forced the country to sell crude at steep discounts on informal markets, reversing recent gains and pushing inflation back upward from 71.7 percent in 2024 toward significantly higher forecasts for 2025.

Sub-point: Mass Displacement as a Consequence

The compounding effect of hyperinflation and sanctions has driven one of the largest displacement crises in modern Latin American history. By the end of 2024, more than 7.9 million Venezuelans, roughly a quarter of the country's population, had left the country, with Colombia alone hosting approximately 2.8 million migrants.

Sub-point: A Fractured and Ineffective Opposition

Despite widespread public discontent, the Venezuelan opposition has repeatedly failed to translate economic grievance into a unified political challenge. The 2019 declaration of Juan Guaidó as interim president, backed initially by Brazil, Chile, Colombia, and the United States, represented the most significant attempt to establish an alternative center of power. However, this effort steadily lost momentum, and by 2023 even the United States had withdrawn its recognition of Guaidó, following the lead of the Venezuelan opposition itself, which had abandoned the strategy amid internal disagreement over tactics and legitimacy. This repeated failure to sustain a credible, unified opposition has left a vacuum that extra-constitutional actors, rather than electoral politics, have increasingly moved to fill.

Impacts

1. Mass Migration Crisis Across Latin America

Venezuela's economic and political collapse has produced one of the largest displacement crises in modern Latin American history. By the end of 2024, more than 7.9 million Venezuelans, roughly a quarter of the country's total population, had left the country in search of stability abroad, depriving Venezuela of much of its skilled workforce in the process. As of June 2024, approximately 7.7 million Venezuelans were living abroad, constituting close to 22.5 percent of the estimated national population, with projections estimating the figure could reach as high as 8.4 million by 2025 under continued instability.

Sub-point: Regional Distribution and Host-Country Strain

The overwhelming majority of these migrants, an estimated 6.7 million, reside within Latin America and the Caribbean itself, placing direct and sustained pressure on neighboring economies and social services. Colombia has absorbed the largest share, hosting approximately 2.8 million Venezuelan migrants, while Brazil, Chile, Ecuador, and Peru have also become major host countries navigating the strain on housing, healthcare, and labor markets.

Sub-point: Labor Market and Fiscal Spillovers

Beyond the humanitarian dimension, this migration wave carries substantial macroeconomic consequences for the region. Studies of the crisis have found that within Venezuela itself, formal employment in the public and private sectors fell by 15 percentage points between 2014 and 2019/2020, while self-employment rose

to 45 percent of the workforce, reflecting the broader collapse of stable economic structures that has pushed so many to leave. For recipient countries such as Colombia, the fiscal and labor market spillovers from absorbing millions of new migrants have become a significant and ongoing policy challenge, with growth accounting studies conducted specifically to measure this impact since 2017.

Sub-point: Vulnerable Populations and Dangerous Migration Routes

The crisis has increasingly affected vulnerable groups, including unaccompanied minors. Migration of children and adolescents through the dangerous Darién Gap in Panama rose by 40 percent in a single year, according to UNICEF, underscoring how deteriorating conditions inside Venezuela are pushing even the most vulnerable populations toward increasingly perilous routes out of the country.

2. Regional Split Over Recognition of Legitimacy, Weakening OAS Credibility

The question of who legitimately governs Venezuela has repeatedly fractured consensus within the OAS, undermining the Organization's ability to present a unified hemispheric response. This division was most starkly visible in 2019, when the National Assembly declared Juan Guaidó interim president, prompting Brazil, Chile, and Colombia to publicly align behind his leadership as part of the broader Lima Group coalition, while Russia, Cuba, and other allied states maintained firm recognition of Maduro's government.

Sub-point: The Collapse of the Guaidó Recognition Strategy

This split proved ultimately unsustainable. International support for Guaidó steadily eroded over subsequent years, and by 2023 the United States itself withdrew recognition of him as Venezuela's legitimate leader, following the lead of the Venezuelan opposition, which had already abandoned the strategy amid internal disputes. Meanwhile, Maduro's international standing partially recovered as leaders more sympathetic to his government took office in Mexico, Colombia, and Brazil, demonstrating how quickly hemispheric consensus on recognition can shift and reverse.

Sub-point: Repeated but Inconclusive Resolutions

Despite passing a series of resolutions condemning Venezuela's democratic backsliding, including Resolution 1078 in 2017, Resolution 2929 in 2018, and further resolutions in 2019 and following the disputed 2024 election, the OAS has consistently stopped short of decisive enforcement action such as formal suspension under Article 21 of the Inter-American Democratic Charter. This pattern

of strong rhetorical condemnation without binding consequence has raised persistent questions about the Organization's actual capacity to enforce its own democratic charter.

Sub-point: Erosion of Hemispheric Credibility

Each cycle of division and reversal has cumulatively weakened the perception of the OAS as a body capable of decisive, consistent action on democratic breaches. This credibility gap now directly shapes the stakes of the current crisis: how the Committee responds to the coerced abduction and the question of recognizing the Rodríguez government will either help restore confidence in the OAS's ability to enforce its founding principles, or further cement the perception that its resolutions carry limited practical weight when member states' interests diverge.

Points to Be Considered within debate

1. Legality of the Seizure/Abduction Itself

Delegates must determine whether the coerced removal of the president constitutes an unlawful act of political violence and a criminal violation of international norms protecting heads of state, or whether it can instead be framed as a justified response to alleged criminal conduct on the president's part. This determination is foundational, as it shapes every subsequent decision the Committee makes regarding recognition, sanctions, or intervention. Delegates should also consider who carried out the abduction, whether internal factions, foreign actors, or a combination of both, as the identity and motive of the perpetrators will heavily influence how the act is legally characterized.

2. Electoral Pathway and Timeline Going Forward

With no constitutionally sanctioned leader currently in place, delegates must debate how and when Venezuela can return to a legitimate electoral process. This includes discussing realistic timelines that balance the urgency of restoring democratic order against the practical challenges of organizing free and fair elections amid ongoing instability. Delegates should also consider the role of international election observers, what safeguards are needed to prevent manipulation by any transitional authority, and whether interim governance structures should have a fixed expiration date tied directly to the electoral calendar.

3. Sovereignty vs. the "Narco-State" Justification, and Its Precedent for the Hemisphere

Delegates must weigh whether labeling Venezuela a "narco-state" provides

legitimate grounds for external actors to justify the abduction as a necessary security measure, or whether this framing sets a dangerous and easily abused precedent that could be selectively applied by powerful states to justify future interventions against weaker or politically inconvenient governments. This debate sits at the core of the broader tension between respecting state sovereignty, a founding principle of the OAS Charter, and addressing legitimate transnational security threats such as organized crime and drug trafficking networks operating with alleged state complicity.

4. Recognition of the Rodríguez Government

Delegates must decide whether to extend, withhold, or conditionally grant recognition to the Rodríguez government as Venezuela's legitimate interim authority. This includes considering what specific benchmarks, such as committing to a fixed electoral timeline, releasing political prisoners, or accepting international oversight, might justify conditional recognition. Delegates should also weigh the risks on both sides: premature recognition could legitimize an unconstitutional transfer of power and encourage similar actions elsewhere, while prolonged non-recognition risks deepening the power vacuum and worsening instability inside Venezuela.

5. Role of Foreign Actors (US, Colombia, Russia, Cuba)

Delegates must examine how external powers with sharply competing interests are shaping the trajectory of the crisis. This includes considering potential US and Colombian involvement in, or tacit support for, the abduction given their historical opposition to the Maduro government, as well as Russian and Cuban resistance to any narrative that frames the seizure as legitimate, given their longstanding political and economic ties to Venezuela's ruling apparatus. Understanding these competing agendas is essential to predicting whether a Committee resolution can achieve genuine consensus or will instead be undermined by great power rivalry playing out through regional proxies.

6. Case Study: 2019 Guaidó–Maduro Dual-Presidency Crisis

This precedent illustrates the risks of competing claims to legitimate authority splitting hemispheric consensus and ultimately failing to produce lasting change. Delegates should examine how initial widespread recognition of Guaidó by the US and several Latin American states gradually eroded over time, culminating in even the US withdrawing recognition by 2023, and consider what this reveals about the dangers of recognizing an alternative government without a credible, sustainable

path to consolidating actual control. This case is directly relevant to evaluating whether recognizing the Rodríguez government risks repeating the same cycle of fractured, externally contested legitimacy.

7. Case Study: Bolivia's 2019 Morales Ousting as Regional Precedent

This case offers a comparative example of a Latin American leader's removal from power amid deeply disputed circumstances, with the international community sharply divided between framing it as a legitimate response to electoral fraud and condemning it as an unconstitutional coup. Delegates should examine how this division shaped Bolivia's subsequent political instability and consider whether the international response set a useful precedent for handling extra constitutional transitions, or whether it instead demonstrates the long term risks of failing to reach clear hemispheric consensus in the immediate aftermath of such a crisis.

Past UN Actions

1. UN Security Council Meeting on Venezuela, 2019

The United Nations Security Council held meetings on the political crisis in Venezuela and called for restraint, peaceful dialogue, and a political solution to the crisis.

2. UN Security Council Draft Resolution on Venezuela, 2019

A draft resolution proposed free and fair presidential elections, international electoral observation, protection of members of the Venezuelan National Assembly, and humanitarian assistance. The resolution was vetoed by China and Russia.

3. UN Human Rights Council Resolution 57/36, 2024

The Human Rights Council adopted a resolution addressing the human rights situation in Venezuela. It called for continued monitoring and attention to violations of human rights and fundamental freedoms.

4. Independent International Fact Finding Mission on Venezuela

The UN Human Rights Council established an independent fact finding mission to investigate alleged human rights violations and abuses in Venezuela. The mission has continued producing reports on the country's political and human rights situation.

5. UN Human Rights Office Reports on Venezuela

The Office of the UN High Commissioner for Human Rights has published

reports documenting concerns involving political participation, arbitrary detention, freedom of expression, and other fundamental rights in Venezuela.

6. **UN Security Council Meeting Following the 2026 Abduction of Nicolás Maduro**

Following the January 2026 US military operation in Venezuela and the removal of President Nicolás Maduro, the Security Council met to discuss the situation. Members debated sovereignty, territorial integrity, the use of force, and compliance with the UN Charter.

7. **Statement by the UN Secretary General, January 2026**

The Secretary General stressed the importance of respecting the UN Charter, Venezuela's sovereignty and territorial integrity, and the prohibition on the threat or use of force. He also called for an inclusive political dialogue led by Venezuelans.

8. **UN General Assembly President's Statement, January 2026**

The President of the General Assembly emphasized the principles of sovereignty and territorial integrity and referred to Article 2 of the UN Charter concerning the prohibition of the threat or use of force against states.

9. **UN Charter and Venezuelan Sovereignty**

The UN Charter provides the main legal framework for the international response to the Venezuelan crisis. Article 2 establishes principles including sovereign equality, peaceful settlement of disputes, and restrictions on the use of force.

10. **UN Human Rights Council Monitoring**

The Human Rights Council has continued to monitor Venezuela through resolutions, investigations, and reporting mechanisms, particularly regarding political freedoms, democratic participation, and alleged human rights violations.

Stakeholders: State Actors

1. **Venezuela**

The Venezuelan government is the central state actor. Its interests include maintaining national sovereignty, political control, territorial integrity, and control over the country's institutions.

2. **United States**

The United States is directly involved because of its actions toward the Venezuelan government and its role in the removal and detention of Nicolás

Maduro. Its interests include security, regional stability, and political developments in Venezuela.

3. **Russia**

Russia has maintained close political and military relations with Venezuela and has supported the Venezuelan government. Russia is also a permanent member of the UN Security Council, giving it significant influence over international responses.

4. **China**

China has important economic and diplomatic relations with Venezuela and has supported the principle of state sovereignty and non interference in domestic affairs.

5. **Cuba**

Cuba has historically maintained close political relations with the Venezuelan government and has provided cooperation in areas such as security, healthcare, and technical assistance.

6. **Colombia**

Colombia shares a long border with Venezuela and is directly affected by political instability, migration, border security, and armed groups operating in the region.

7. **Brazil**

Brazil is one of Venezuela's largest neighbours and has an interest in regional stability, border security, migration, and peaceful resolution of the Venezuelan crisis.

8. **Guyana**

Guyana is an important stakeholder because of the longstanding territorial dispute between Guyana and Venezuela over the Essequibo region. Political instability in Venezuela can also affect regional security.

9. **European Union Member States**

European states have been involved in diplomatic efforts concerning Venezuela and have interests relating to democracy, human rights, migration, and regional stability.

10. **United Nations**

The UN is a major international stakeholder because the situation involves questions of sovereignty, use of force, political legitimacy, human rights, and international peace and security.

Agenda 2: The collapse of State Authority and the Siege of Port AU Prince by Gangs in Haiti

Introduction to Agenda

The erosion of governmental authority is seldom the result of an actual lack of government. Rather, it starts with the inability of institutions to enforce laws, ensure security, offer basic services, and maintain the trust of its people. The situation in Haiti is a prime example of how these elements have been degraded, leading to one of the most serious humanitarian and governance crises in the Caribbean region.

The political history of Haiti has seen recurring instances of instability following the departure of the Duvalier government in 1986. With coups, disputes about political transition, weak institutions, and lengthy spells without proper democratic governance interrupting the development of a functional state, the 2010 earthquake added even more strain on already weak infrastructure and institutions. The departure of multiple UN missions in Haiti could not solve its structural problems.

The security conditions worsened drastically after the killing of the Haitian president Jovenel Moïse in July 2021. As a result of the political vacuum and the limited capacity of the Haitian National Police, the criminal groups gained more territories and power, mostly in Port-au-Prince and surrounding areas. In addition, these gangs controlled the local neighbourhoods, transportation routes, markets, and other infrastructure. They were actively conducting extortion, kidnappings, and violent activities against the local population.

The crisis reached its peak in 2024, when the attack of the criminal groups was directed at police stations, prisons, government facilities, and other infrastructure. This situation led to disruption of important transport routes and supplies and prevented civilians from accessing food, medicines, healthcare services, and humanitarian assistance. Moreover, large scale displacement took place due to violence that spread among communities.

Nevertheless, the crisis in Haiti goes far beyond just Port-au-Prince. Violent acts have been increasingly seen in other parts of the country, while displacement, food insecurity, economic disruption, and the strain on neighboring countries have led to

regional impacts as well. The international community - through the political involvement of the United Nations, sanctions, humanitarian aid, and the Multinational Security Support mission – has been trying to assist Haiti in building its institutions and providing security.

Overall, the issue goes beyond fighting the gangs. It is about rebuilding the basis of the state power - functional institutions, reliable security sector, access to justice, humanitarian protection, political stability, and basic services. Hence, the core question is how to provide a path for the Haitian-led process of security and governance.

Key Terms and Definition

Authority of State: The authority of the government in enforcing law, administering territory, providing public services, and maintaining order.

Fragility of State: The situation where institutions in the government do not have the capability and legitimacy in governing, securing, and meeting the demands of its citizens.

Collapse of the State: The extreme failure of governmental institutions in exercising authority over territory and population.

Governance: The manner by which political power is exercised and decisions are made.

Political Instability: The disruption of political institutions, leaders, or constitutionally defined governance, causing ineffective and unpredictable administration.

Armed Groups: A group that is armed and functions outside the normal structure of state security. This is specifically referring to gangs that control territories in Haiti and are involved in violent activities.

Territorial Control of Gangs: The capacity of an armed criminal organization to exercise influence over specific geographical territories, including movement, trade, and civilian activities.

Gangs Coalition: A coalition of armed groups working together for their mutual benefit.

Viv Ansanm: A coalition of Haitian armed gangs which gained prominence in 2024 and carried out coordinated assaults in Port-au-Prince.

Port-au-Prince: Capital city of Haiti and the country's largest urban area, which has become the primary locus of gang violence in the country.

Haitian National Police (HNP): Haiti's main law enforcement agency tasked with ensuring public security and countering criminal activities.

Humanitarian Crisis: A situation where a substantial number of people are exposed to significant threats to their security, wellbeing, living conditions or basic needs.

Internal Displacement: Movement of people away from their place of habitual residence while remaining within the boundaries of their country.

Humanitarian Access: The possibility for humanitarian agencies and workers to gain access to areas affected by humanitarian crises.

Food Insecurity: Situation where people have no reliable access to adequate amounts of food that is safe and

History and Background

1957 - 1986 - Duvalier Dictatorship

The regime of François "Papa Doc" Duvalier began its operation in 1957, when this politician seized power and established an authoritarian regime that would influence Haiti's political and security situation for many years to come. The government of Papa Doc operated with the help of violence, intimidation, and Tonton Macoute, which was a paramilitary formation used to suppress political opposition and ensure political control. In 1971, after the death of Papa Doc, his son Jean-Claude "Baby Doc" Duvalier took power and continued the operation of the authoritarian regime. Although some reforms concerning economy and politics were implemented, repression and corruption played a significant role in the country's political life. In 1986, due to public unrest and growing opposition, Jean-Claude Duvalier had to leave the country, thus terminating the Duvalier dictatorship era.

1986 - 2004 - Political Instability & Coups

The end of the rule of the Duvalier regime in 1986 became the start of a long period of transition to a new system and not stability. There have been many changes of

governments, violence and disruption of institutions in Haiti. In 1990, Jean-Bertrand Aristide was elected president of Haiti through the country's first internationally acknowledged democratic election. However, in 1991, Aristide was deposed through a military coup. Aristide was returned to power in 1994 under international pressure, but the country's army was dissolved and the Haitian National Police (HNP) was created. Despite this, political tension still existed, especially during election periods and different political groups. In 2004, a rebellion and a political situation forced Aristide to leave Haiti. The unstable situation allowed for the growth of armed groups due to difficulties in maintaining constant control over the state institutions.

2004 - 2017 - MINUSTAH & International Stabilization

After the political crisis that took place in 2004, the United Nations created the United Nations Stabilization Mission in Haiti (MINUSTAH), which aimed at improving security and political stability and building up the institutions. During the period of its mandate, which lasted thirteen years, MINUSTAH operated together with the authorities of Haiti and assisted in solving issues related to policing, holding elections, developing infrastructure and establishing public order. Nevertheless, Haiti still had a number of structural problems: poverty, political instability, weak institutions and organized violence. In addition, 2010 was the year when the earthquake took place and caused destruction in Port-au-Prince and destroyed state infrastructure and public services. The international community helped in restoring infrastructure, but there were many problems in institutions, which stayed unsolved. In 2017, MINUSTAH completed its work and its tasks were transferred to the new mission of the United Nations.

2018 - 2021 - Expansion of Gang Power

From 2018 to 2021, Haiti witnessed a significant decline in its political, economic, and security environment. Protest actions related to rising fuel prices, corruption, and poor governance often disturbed daily activities, while armed groups continued expanding their territorial control, especially within the metropolitan region of Port-au-Prince. Major gangs were competing for the dominance of the territory, transport routes, and areas that have a strategic significance for them. In 2020, alliances between powerful gangs, including the G9 Family and Allies, were formed, showing how well-organized armed groups became at that time. Gang-related violence involved such criminal acts as kidnappings, extortions, territorial fights, and even assaults on government bodies. The political situation deteriorated after the assassination of President Jovenel Moïse on 7 July 2021, when the country lost its president through elections.

2022 - 2024 - Port-AU-Prince Siege & Collapse of Authority

Since 2022, the presence and influence of gangs have increased dramatically in the area of Port-au-Prince and beyond, becoming a major challenge for the Haitian government to secure the population and deliver necessary services. Roads, neighbourhoods, and infrastructure became either contested or controlled by the gangs, and violence hampered people's access to food, fuel, health care, education, and humanitarian assistance. In February-March 2024, the attacks on police stations, prisons, government buildings, and other strategic sites carried out by organized armed groups reached a critical stage. The emergence and growth of the alliance between the armed groups, Viv Ansanm, were yet another illustration of how organized these gangs were. The Prime Minister, Ariel Henry, then agreed to resign, and the governing system of transitional government was set up.

Present Situation

Gang control in Haiti still remains significant, especially in and around Port-au-Prince, though the problem continues to extend outside the capital city. According to UN reports published in 2026, gangs remain to be operating within organized networks controlling territories and restricting movement and posing challenges to state authority. Gangs do not only control residential neighborhoods but important routes for transportation and economy. Security interventions have managed to weaken some gangs and slow down their territorial expansion; however, it is emphasized that these achievements can easily be reversed without continuous security and institutional capacity building. Violence also extends to departments such as Centre, Artibonite, Northwest, and South, showing that the problem is no longer limited to the capital. In August 2026, an incident took place in Kenscoff, which is located above Port-au-Prince, and 47 people were killed through kidnapping and displacement of people. This incident was cited by UN representatives as an example of gangs' capability of expanding their influence.

The political institutions in Haiti are still undergoing transition. As such, the Transitional Presidential Council (TPC) established in 2024 has now come to the end of its mandate on 7 February 2026 without conducting the much-awaited national elections. It then fell upon the Council of Ministers, which is headed by the country's Prime Minister, Didier Fils-Aimé, to assume executive power. In February 2026, Haitian stakeholders agreed to a National Pact for Stability and the Organization of Elections aimed at ensuring political cooperation and making it possible for elections to be held. Despite this, insecurity continues to hinder the

conduct of elections. According to CARICOM in August 2026, it was not possible to hold elections as planned because of insecurity. They were initially planned to be conducted in August but had to be postponed, and voter registration was done in July 2026.

The security situation has led to an acute humanitarian crisis which is impacting many Haitians. As of mid-2026, an estimated 1.47 million people are internally displaced, with violence becoming the primary cause of displacement outside Port-au-Prince. According to UN reports, about 80% of internal displacement in 2025 happened outside the capital city, thus indicating the spread of the crisis geographically. The situation has worsened issues of food insecurity, access to healthcare and education facilities and put extreme pressure on communities hosting the displaced population. Humanitarian organizations have been having trouble accessing communities affected by the crisis because of repeated disruptions and restrictions along important transport corridors. Children have become the most vulnerable group as well; according to UN reports, the recruitment and use of children by gangs increased almost threefold in 2025 as compared to 2024, and children constituted 30-50% of gangs.

The Haitian authorities, along with their international partners, have been trying to build up their security capabilities through enhanced collaboration between the Haitian National Police, Haitian security institutions, and the Gang Suppression Force (GSF) supported by the international community. In 2025-2026, the security activities managed to hinder the gang activity and slow down their spread of territory in Port-au-Prince. Nonetheless, it should be noted that the UN pointed out that solely military or policing activities cannot solve the situation. Meanwhile, the Gang Suppression Force has experienced delays in becoming fully deployed and its mandate is about to expire soon. However, the international community's efforts are also aimed at developing Haitian policing and implementing more comprehensive disarming, dismantling, and reintegration strategies.

Human rights abuses continue to be one of the most prominent characteristics of the ongoing crisis in Haiti. For instance, according to the reports of the UN for the year 2026, killings, abduction, sexual assault, recruitment of children, and attacks on civilians were rampant. Between April and June 2026, BINUH recorded 1,408 deaths and 656 injuries. Despite that, the government of Haiti continues to struggle in providing the necessary services in areas where violence has occurred.

Humanitarian assistance has also continued to be selective, while education institutions, health facilities, markets, and transport networks have been disrupted. However, despite that, there is evidence that some improvements have been made, since coordination in security has led to improved security in certain parts of the country, and some displaced persons have started to return to their homes cautiously. According to the UN, such positive developments require constant effort in security, governance, justice, humanitarian assistance, livelihood, and democracy in order to sustain them.

The Siege of Port-au-Prince

The siege of Port-au-Prince embodies the most intensive illustration of the failure of Haitian state authority, as the capital city has increasingly become the key site where territorial control, policing, politics, and access to basic needs merge. By early 2025, according to the United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime (UNODC), about 85 percent of Port-au-Prince was under the rule of criminal gangs, though the exact percentage has varied depending on the methodology and timeframe used. Gang dominance had been most intense around the critical sites of neighbourhoods and transportation routes, such as those adjacent to the national port and major transportation arteries between the capital and other departments. For example, the northern downtown area had been ruled by Krache Dife, Les Argentins and La Saline since 2021, earning income from extortion, truck robbery, theft of cargo, and kidnapping.

From 29 February to March 2024, there were armed group attacks on the police stations, prisons, and strategic infrastructure of government offices, which escalated significantly. Two prisons in Haiti were subjected to attacks, resulting in the escape of about 4,600 inmates, while attacks were made on the National Palace several times, with the UN recording at least 10 major attacks on the palace in March 2024. Gang attacks on 11 November 2024 even closed down the international airport of Port-au-Prince following the attack of an aircraft. Other ramifications involved the blockade of routes that made it difficult for food, fuel, medical supplies, and humanitarian aid workers to reach their destination, as well as constant disruptions in businesses, schools, hospitals, and markets. Therefore, the siege is not only about widespread criminal acts but also about the reduced capability of the state to secure its capital city.

Gang Governance and Territorial Control

The gang presence in Haiti has evolved from individual acts of crime into control over territories and economic gains. There are armed groups operating in the neighborhoods of Port-au-Prince and other regions with strongholds in these areas through control of roads, markets, harbors and means of transport to earn money and limit movement. UNODC has made connections between the territorial expansion of the gangs to illegal arms and drugs dealing, corruption and money laundering whereas UN reports indicate cases of extortion, kidnapping, illegal taxation and hijacking of commercial vehicles. In the case of the northern part of downtown Port-au-Prince, control of the region has allowed the gangs to earn money from commercial transactions and movement through the proximity of the region to the national harbor increasing its significance. This poses a major difference between sovereignty and effective power since the Haitian government has legal sovereignty over the territory while it lacks administrative and security control in areas occupied by armed groups.

The control of territories by gangs also means the development of alternative coercive mechanisms that prevent the normal functioning of the state. Movement between the neighborhoods may be restricted for the residents, while enterprises and transportation can be exposed to blackmailing. It is impossible for humanitarian organizations to work with the community when the corridors are controlled by armed groups, and conducting police work becomes harder due to the impossibility to keep permanent positions of police officers. Thus, it is not only the fact that gangs possess physical territories; it is about who can move, trade, and have access to particular services. According to the UN representatives in 2025, the armed gangs had control of around 85 percent of Port-au-Prince, and the Security Council singled out such forms of violent actions of the gangs as the use of violence, kidnapping, trafficking, the forced recruitment of children, and sexual and gender-based violence in Haiti.

Collapse of the Haitian Security Apparatus

One of the ways in which gang power has led to the disintegration of state power is through the weakness of the Haitian security structures. The Haitian National Police (HNP) is the primary security force for Haiti, but it has been plagued by insufficient manpower, equipment, capacity and even a lack of secure infrastructure in the face of increasingly well-organized and armed gangs. This was especially evident in the February-March 2024 attacks when, along with attacks on prisons and government institutions and other strategically important locations, attacks were launched

against police stations. The loss of police posts through destruction, desertion or seizure has hampered the state's ability to establish itself continuously in terms of security.

Attacks on prisons in March 2024 showed that a failure of one part of the infrastructure would bring down the whole security infrastructure. Some 4,600 inmates, charged with and even convicted of serious crimes, were freed from jails when armed gangs attacked the largest prisons in Haiti. The situation called for international assistance with the creation of the MSS, or Multinational Security Support, according to UN Security Council Resolution 2699 passed on 2 October 2023, aimed at assisting HNP and creating conditions for humanitarian and political stabilization in the country. Still, international security assistance alone is not a remedy to fix the malfunctioning state apparatus in Haiti. The critical issue here is that of rebuilding an efficient security and justice system from the level of police presence and investigations up to prosecuting, trials, and detentions of convicts in prisons throughout Port-au-Prince.

Viv Ansanm and the Coordination of Armed Groups

"Viv Ansanm," which translates to "Living Together," marks a significant shift in the way armed groups in Haiti have been organized due to the merging of different gang blocks into one larger coalition. As reported by the UN Security Council, Viv Ansanm was created in September 2023 through a partnership between the G-9 and G-Pèp, which are two key gang factions active in the Haitian capital, and was led by Jimmy Chérizier. This coalition later came back to life on 29 February 2024 during the onset of a massive offensive campaign. In place of focusing their violence on competition between different neighbourhood gangs, the coalition served as an organizing tool in the fight against the state apparatus and strategic facilities.

It became clear especially with the escalation in February/March 2024 and the coordinated attacks, which led to the deterioration of the security situation in Port-au-Prince, as well as to the deepening of the political crisis, which eventually resulted in the resignation of Prime Minister Ariel Henry. Attacks on the National Palace are also mentioned repeatedly in UN reports, with at least 10 such attacks in early March 2024 alone. Subsequently, Viv Ansanm has been sanctioned by the UN Security Council via its Haiti Sanctions Committee on 8 July 2025, in accordance with Resolution 2653 (2022). The sanctions regime includes measures such as a travel ban, asset freeze and arms embargo, taking the applicable exemptions into

account. It also includes the formal designation of Viv Ansanm for its involvement in activities which threaten the peace, security and stability of Haiti. Thus, Viv Ansanm has direct bearing on the agenda since it illustrates how fragmented criminal groups cooperate across borders in their territorial base and collectively target police stations, jails and other infrastructure.

Causes

Political Instability and Institutional Vacuum

A major reason for the ongoing crisis in Haiti is the instability and vulnerability of its political institutions. Haiti has had to deal with numerous coups, disputed political transitions, claims of corruption, and instances of no fully functional elected government institutions. The assassination of President Jovenel Moïse in July 2021 added to the existing political vacuum in the country by leaving Haiti without an elected head of state and undermining the credibility of state institutions. This was further complicated by the fact that the country had trouble organizing national elections and that the transitional governments did not have full capability of governing the entire territory of Haiti. As political institutions started to fail in terms of decision-making and enforcement capabilities, gangs were able to increase their reach in territories where state institutions already had limited authority. The instability of the political system also affected the functioning of other state institutions such as the police and courts by depriving them of necessary resources and organization. Therefore, one cannot say that the crisis in Haiti is caused by the gang activity alone since it coincided with the gradual breakdown of political power.

Weakness of the Haitian National Police and Security Institutions

Another key reason why gangs have been able to grow in Haiti has been due to the low capacity of the security institutions. The Haitian National Police is the main body responsible for law-enforcement in the country, but it has had problems with lack of resources, including staff, equipment, funding, and capability to enforce law effectively. In places where there are few police forces or the stations have been attacked by armed groups, these have managed to establish their control relatively easily. This becomes even more pronounced where police officers themselves are attacked, making effective law enforcement even harder to maintain. This is exacerbated by the poor performance of the judicial system – arrests cannot be followed up with successful trials because of the vulnerabilities of courts, prisons, and the judicial process itself. This creates a vicious cycle where the weakness of institutions leads to insecurity, but insecurity makes it even harder to build strong

institutions. Despite international support to improve law enforcement and security institutions in Haiti, the lack of internal strength persists.

Expansion and Organization of Armed Gangs Poverty

The crisis in Haiti has also been fuelled by the evolution of gangs from simple criminal organizations into highly organized territorial entities. Over the years, gangs formed networks that could control neighborhoods, extort money, engage in kidnappings, and interfere with transport and commerce. The development of alliances like G9 Family and Allies and G-Pèp, and the creation of Viv Ansanm in 2024, were an indication of growing abilities to coordinate major armed groups. They have been empowered by the availability of weapons, financial means, and strategic positions in and around Port-au-Prince. Control of roads and routes gives gangs leverage over the movement of citizens, commercial items, fuels, and humanitarian aid. Lack of services from the government in some areas has facilitated the establishment of informal control mechanisms by the gangs. It is not that the gangs completely took over the role of the state in a conventional sense but that they became powerful enough to limit the functioning of the state.

Economic Vulnerability and Lack of Opportunities

The very serious socioeconomic problems in Haiti have made communities and institutions highly vulnerable to violence. Many communities within the country suffer from poverty, unemployment, low levels of education, and poor provision of public goods and services. Economic instability makes communities vulnerable to recruitment, threats of violence, extortion, and dependency on armed groups. At the same time, because there is little opportunity for economic development, criminal organizations get a chance to make profit out of their violent activities such as kidnappings, extortion, illegal taxation, and protection of commercial routes. Violence further destabilizes the economy by disrupting economic activities such as business and agricultural practices, transportation, and supply chains. Since economic activities take place mostly around Port-au-Prince, control over transport and markets is particularly important for armed groups. Economic hardship in itself does not lead to violence and most people who live in poverty in Haiti are not involved in any armed gangs. Economic instability becomes dangerous when combined with other factors such as weak institutions, lack of jobs, and insecurity.

Natural Disasters and Repeated Humanitarian Shocks

Recurring natural disasters have also weakened the country's institutions and economy. The earthquake that hit Port-au-Prince in 2010 was one such disaster, having brought damage to governmental institutions, residential buildings, educational facilities, healthcare establishments, and other infrastructures. Haiti

needed to cope with huge reconstruction challenges at a time when the country's institutions were having difficulties managing their resources. Another natural disaster was the earthquake of 2021 in the south of the country, which increased the country's humanitarian crisis at a time of extreme political and security instability. Environmental disasters such as hurricanes, floods, and others have also harmed infrastructures and displaced populations. While it is obvious that such disasters do not explain the formation of the country's gangs, they have been a constant challenge to the government's functioning through recurrent destruction of livelihoods and governmental infrastructures. Furthermore, displacement may increase problems of vulnerable urban populations while the destruction of roads and other infrastructures makes it difficult for governments and humanitarian organizations to reach the affected regions.

Impacts

Economic Impacts

Gang violence in Haiti has greatly impacted its already weak economy, which has experienced six consecutive years of recession with an estimated reduction in GDP growth of 4.2% in 2024. Extortion, destruction, and closure of businesses have occurred due to gang control of major highways and economic corridors, while the movement of basic goods such as food and fuel has been affected. The Port-au-Prince seaport has been closed for weeks from March to April 2024, while the city's international airport has also been shut down for several months, limiting economic transactions and mobility. At the end of the fiscal year 2025, inflation is estimated at 32%, further reducing consumer spending power. The economic turmoil in Haiti has limited employment and investments while increasing dependence on humanitarian aid. As criminals exercise control over strategic economic routes and earn illegal income through extortion and other methods, it becomes even more challenging for the economy to operate normally.

Socio-Humanitarian Impacts

Humanitarian implications have taken on an unprecedented scale. Up to 1.4-1.5 million internally displaced persons (IDPs) emerged in Haiti by 2026 due to the widespread gang violence and insecurity. Approximately 5.8 million people suffered from acute food insecurity, and disruption of transportation routes and humanitarian access has led to increased difficulties in delivering necessary supplies. In particular, the situation is dire in the sphere of healthcare, where medical institutions have shut down or operate under severely limited capacity due to violence and insecurity. Similarly, schools have either been damaged, closed, or rendered inaccessible in

regions controlled by the armed actors. Children are more exposed to being recruited, and women and girls suffer from sexual and gender-based violence disproportionately. Up to 3,050 murders and 1,088 cases of sexual violence have been registered in UN reports for the first half of 2026. Thus, one can see that the crisis goes beyond a conflict between the Haitian government and non-state actors and turns into a crisis of civilian protection, displacement, food security, health care, and education.

Geo Political Impacts

The instability in Haiti has grown into a broader regional Caribbean issue in relation to displacement, migration, border security, and involvement in international security issues. The Dominican Republic that shares the island of Hispaniola with Haiti has been put under severe pressure regarding its border and issues of migration. The crisis has also involved major international efforts of cooperation of the United Nations, CARICOM and neighboring countries. Following the deterioration of security in Haiti, the UN Security Council has allowed the formation of an international security mission that was supposed to support the efforts of the Haitian government and Haitian National Police in addressing the armed gangs. As such, the crisis in Haiti poses a broader issue in diplomacy – how can the outsiders help to restore security and institutions in Haiti without undermining its sovereignty and political leadership? The instability in Haiti can also affect the regional economic cooperation, supply lines, migration management and security cooperation in the Caribbean region.

Past Action

Past United Nations Action

UN Peacekeeping: MINUSTAH (2004–2017)

After Haiti's political crisis of 2004 and the removal of President Jean-Bertrand Aristide from office, the United Nations Security Council set up the United Nations Stabilization Mission in Haiti (MINUSTAH) under resolution 1542 of 30 April 2004. It took charge of the operation from the Multinational Interim Force on 1 June 2004. At the time, MINUSTAH was authorized a maximum of 6,700 military personnel and 1,622 police personnel. MINUSTAH had several mandates including support of political dialogue and elections, human rights protection, disarmament initiatives, and building of the Haitian National Police. It stayed in Haiti for about 13 years through successive political crises, natural disasters, and security situations. After the earthquake of 2010 that claimed 250,000 lives and 102 UN personnel, MINUSTAH was involved in humanitarian and relief work. In 2017, the Security

Council realized that the situation in Haiti allowed for the transition to a smaller peacekeeping operation. The MINUSTAH mission officially concluded on 15 October 2017 as its functions were handed over to a smaller justice and police support mission.

MINUJUSTH & BINUH: Institutional Support (2017–Present)

Since the closure of MINUSTAH, the United Nations has taken the course of consolidating Haiti's domestic institutions instead of peacekeeping operations on a grand scale. In 2017, the United Nations Mission for Justice Support in Haiti (MINUJUSTH) was formed with an emphasis on building up the Haitian National Police, reforming the justice sector, promoting human rights, and the rule of law. In accordance with Resolution 2466 (2019), the mandate of the mission was prolonged until 15 October 2019. After the transition, the United Nations Integrated Office in Haiti (BINUH) was set up via Resolution 2476 on 25 June 2019 adopted with a vote of 13-0-2. The new organization does not fall into the category of peacekeeping operation in the way MINUSTAH did. Its main functions included political dialogue, good governance, human rights, rule-of-law institutions, and the Haitian National Police. Thus, in contrast to previous missions, BINUH was more focused on institutional efforts and not the replacement of international forces by national organizations. BINUH soon turned out to be the most important tool of the UN for political work and coordination.

Targeted Sanctions & Arms Measures (2022–Present)

The increasing number of threats posed by armed groups to Haiti's political stability led to the adoption of Resolution 2653 on 21 October 2022 which established a dedicated sanctions regime. It imposed an arms embargo, a travel ban and asset freezes on those who were responsible for or had been complicit in actions that threatened the peace, security or stability of Haiti. The sanctions regime involved the establishment of a Sanctions Committee with 15 members and a request for the appointment of a Panel of Experts, comprising four members, to help with the implementation and monitoring of the sanctions. The sanctions regime explicitly covered the activities related to armed violence, kidnappings, trafficking, migrant smuggling, homicides and sexual and gender-based violence. The Security Council later renewed and modified the sanctions measures. Resolution 2700, in October 2023, renewed the travel and financial sanctions, while Resolution 2699 changed the targeted arms embargo to territorial arms embargo. The sanctions list has since been regularly updated and as at 17 October 2025, there were 9 individuals and 2 entities on the sanctions list.

Multinational Security Support Mission (2023)

Acknowledging the incapacity of security structures in Haiti to curb the rise in gang violence, the UN Security Council adopted Resolution 2699 on 2 October 2023 that established a Multinational Security Support (MSS) mission to be deployed to Haiti. Resolution 2699 offered international legal authorization to deploy the mission that would support the Haitian National Police to restore security and facilitate humanitarian and political stabilization efforts. This effort was different from a traditional UN peacekeeping mission in that it was not a UN peacekeeping mission but an internationally authorized multinational security mission. Kenya took the lead in this mission while other nations later joined in. Further, the resolution also toughened measures in respect of the flow of weapons to Haiti, by replacing the previously imposed arms embargo targeting specific individuals with a territorial-based measure. This mission was to work with the Haitian authorities rather than taking their place. Authorization of the mission included human-rights compliance standards and cooperation with relevant UN mechanisms. This mission marked a departure from the previous international policy of deploying a long-term UN peacekeeping mission to Haiti towards supporting the national institutions in the country.

Past International Action

CARICOM has emerged as an important diplomatic player in the political crisis of Haiti in 2024. On 11 March 2024, CARICOM brought together political parties of Haiti, civil society members, private sector players, religious organizations, and other international partners in Kingston, Jamaica. This was done with the participation of the UN, the USA, Canada, France, Brazil, and Mexico with the objective of ensuring peaceful political transition in addition to taking immediate steps for security and the way forward to elections. In this framework, there is the formation of a Transitional Presidential Council of nine people with seven members having voting rights and two observers.

After Haiti sought assistance from the international community in providing security to the nation, the UNSC approved the deployment of the Kenya led MSS mission through Resolution 2699 on 2 October 2023. The first contingent from Kenya arrived in Port-au-Prince on 25 June 2024. By April 2024, seven countries including Bahamas, Bangladesh, Barbados, Benin, Chad, Jamaica, and Kenya had informed the UN about their personnel deployments, while \$18 million had been transferred to the MSS Trust fund by Canada, France, and the United States. Security Council Resolution 2751 extended the mandate for 12 more months and requested more international personnel and finance in September 2024.

The international humanitarian agencies have been working to provide aid in the form of food, healthcare, shelter, water, sanitation, and protection assistance. More than 700,000 people were internally displaced by November 2024, around 50 percent being children and 5.4 million Haitians facing serious food insecurity. Further, violence near Port-au-Prince caused almost 20,000 more people to be internally displaced within the month of November. Consequently, efforts have been concentrated on keeping the humanitarian corridors open despite insecurity, damaged infrastructure, road blockages, and attacks on facilities, among others.

Further cooperation on an international level has focused on the networks that facilitate criminal gangs, especially the trade of illegal weapons, organized crime, kidnapping, and finance. UNODC and other international allies have helped the Haitian authorities build their capacities in terms of border security, arms control mechanisms, and investigation capabilities. The sanctions policy of the Security Council, formulated in Resolution 2653 (2022), has been imposed in the form of travel prohibitions, asset freeze, and restrictions related to weapons against selected persons and organizations. International allies have also facilitated the training, equipment, and logistics support for the Haitian National Police.

Stake Holders

State Actors

The main state actors in Haiti are the Transitional Presidential Council, the Council of Ministers, the Haitian National Police (HNP), the judiciary, and other state bodies that have been tasked with restoring constitutional governance and public security. The Transitional Presidential Council was formed in April 2024 as a result of the political crisis linked to the resignation of the country's prime minister, Ariel Henry. The term of office of the council expired on 7 February 2026, after which executive power was passed to the Council of Ministers under new Prime Minister Didier Fils-Aimé. A National Pact for Stability and the Organization of Elections was signed on 23 February 2026. In addition to that, HNP continues to be the main security force of the state and conducts operations against armed groups with the help of foreign security partners. Still, the agency is limited in terms of personnel, means of operation, territorial presence, and other institutional factors. Therefore, the Haitian state has become increasingly dependent on foreign aid through the UN-authorized security mission and subsequently the Gang Suppression Force. The

judiciary and the penal system are important state actors because of the long-standing institutional weakness, insecurity in prisons, and impunity.

Another international state system actor is the United Nations, acting through BINUH, the Security Council, and humanitarian organizations, although it does not rule in Haiti. Sanctions, deployment of international security assistance, and the creation of monitoring mechanisms are some of the actions taken by the Security Council. States such as Kenya among others have facilitated the deployment of international security in an effort to assist the HNP instead of replacing Haitian institutions. Financial, logistical, humanitarian, and institutional assistance have also been provided by international partners. This is especially important given the spread of gangs beyond the Port-au-Prince region to other regions like Artibonite and Centre. Reports from the UN in 2025 indicate that armed groups controlled or influenced around 85 percent of the Port-au-Prince metro area. Therefore, the role of state actors has to strike a balance between immediate security activities and reconstruction of law enforcement and governance institutions.

Non State Actors

In terms of Haiti's non-state actors, the country's situation is characterized by the existence of armed gangs and gang alliances that evolved from local criminal organizations into organized networks with territorial, economic, and political power. The most prominent gang alliance includes Viv Ansanm, which was established in September 2023 by merging two different organizations, namely G-9 and G-Pèp, and revived on 29 February 2024. In particular, this coalition organized attacks on police stations, prisons, governmental buildings, and infrastructure facilities resulting in political crisis and resignation of President Ariel Henry. Moreover, the United Nations Security Council included Viv Ansanm into Haiti's sanctions list on 8 July 2025. Another relevant gang includes Gran Grif, the biggest gang in Haiti's Artibonite Department, whose activity according to the report by the Security Council caused about 80 percent of civilian deaths in Artibonite since 2022. These non-state organizations earn money by extorting payments, kidnappings, illegal taxes, among others, and control transportation routes and communities. UN reports claim that the gangs control or influence 85% of metropolitan Port-au-Prince.

In addition to gangs, self-defence groups and "Bwa Kale" community movements have formed as a result of insufficient state protection. Although some communities have established such groups to defend their areas, the UN reporting has also

found these organizations' formation linked with arbitrary violence and retaliation, posing extra difficulties for the restoration of the rule of law. Another group of non-state actors includes civil society organizations, religious organizations, international humanitarian organizations, journalists, and community leaders in the local community. They offer necessary services, report abuses, advocate for civilians and assist in humanitarian operations where the government is unable to do so. International humanitarian organizations have played an especially important role in providing services to displaced people and affected communities. Moreover, children are vulnerable to the actions of the armed groups in particular: according to the UN reporting, they have been recruited by the groups, killed, abducted, subjected to sexual abuse and attacks on schools and hospitals.